

island, it is exposed to the pixelating curse just as the characters are, and might begin to transform.

The monodrone has no name, but it answers to a name given to it by its boss. This is the only word it can speak in addition to its base forty-eight words.

JOURNEY TO THE ISLAND

Sailing for the mysterious Changing Island gives the characters their first glimpse of its mysteries—and its dangers.

THE CHANGING ISLAND

As the characters come within sight of the island, roll a d6. This determines what face of the island is up when they approach, and what the characters see.

Five sides of the island-cube—**faces 1, 2, 3, 4, and 6**—feature a barren, rocky landscape of strangely geometrical terraces in various colors. These terraces are built up of square and rectangular lumps of gray, brown, black, and red stone or clay, though some areas glitter as if lumps of bronze are buried in the ground. The thick fog gives the surface an eerie, twilight look.

By contrast, **face 5** of the cube is a lush green jungle island of palm trees and banana plants. Here, sea waves crash against gentle, sandy beaches, and the fog that covers the island seems less oppressive. (In reality, dead bodies cover this face as they do all other faces of the cube, but they are transformed by the power of the creature that creates this delightful vista. See face 5 for more information.)

No matter which face is on the surface, the island is some 600 feet wide. Circumnavigating the island takes 10 minutes, and confirms that it is almost perfectly square except for a few rocky reefs (or sandbars, if face 5 is up) that jut out into the water at irregular intervals. In addition to the fog, rising hills (and trees if face 5 is up) make it impossible to see all the way across the island without going ashore.

Flying characters can travel above the island and see all of its current face from the air. However, any creature that lands on the island and takes off again is attacked by **vampiric mists** that lurk in the fog. See “Mysterious Fog,” below, and see *Mordenkainen’s Tome of Foes* for more information about the vampiric mist.

Characters who don’t want to risk contact with the black water surrounding the island can use teleportation magic to reach the island safely, and can use such magic on or within the cube. However, the cube’s infernal magic prevents creatures from leaving the island by the use of such magic without the permission of the cube’s ruler, Earl Andromalius—which permission cannot be granted, as Andromalius is dead.

While anywhere within the cube or within 30 feet of its exterior surfaces, a character who attempts to use any teleportation or planar travel magic (including the *plane shift* spell) to leave the cube realizes before the magic is used that it will not work. (A character who persists in trying to use such magic anyway expends its use or wastes a spell slot with no effect.) If the Heart Engine (see area 6.28) is destroyed, this effect ends.

Regardless of which face of the island is up when the characters approach, they also see a derelict drow galley floating several hundred feet away from it. If face 1 or face 2 is up, they see the ship of the ill-fated shadar-kai expedition as well. Countless other bits of timber and floating debris from scuttled ships float around the island, but none are big enough to conclusively identify.

WHAT THE ISLAND TRULY IS

In its true form, the island is a cubical battle station from the plane of Acheron, floating in the Styx sea with only a small portion visible above the surface, like an iceberg. Its form is an iron cube 600 feet on a side, with one to six hatch-like entrances on each face of the cube. The visible face of the cube shows marks of battle: gouges, sections melted from intense heat, and indentations from battering blows. Each face has its own local gravity, though the characters will need to explore to learn this.

The stone terraces of the island are not an illusion. Rather, they are a magical transformation fueled by the pixelating curse. In truth, the surface of each face of the cube is covered with piles of pixelated dead—warriors of various humanoid species, many bearing weapons and armor. Held fast by the local gravity of each face, these are the soldiers of Acheron, including those who were killed by yugoloths when the cube was purged.

Any creature that has the truesight ability, is under the effect of a *true seeing* spell or similar magic, or wears *pixel glasses* (see the “New Magic Items” appendix) can see the island as it truly is. A *dispel magic* or *remove curse* spell also eliminates the pixelating curse from a 10-foot radius of its false surface for 10 minutes, revealing the true form of the pixelated dead. Those dead are piled to heights of 30 feet in some places, with intermittent valleys between those piles revealing the surface of the cube beneath them.

Characters who set foot on the island without seeing its true form have the disturbing experience of touching what looks like dirt and stone but is actually cubical metal, bone, and flesh. Thinking they are walking on rock or clay, they may not realize they are actually walking on pixelated bodies.

Countless dead cover the cube when the characters arrive, and more are shot out onto the surface every hour. Most are warriors who fell during the yugoloth assault, but the broken soul tap (area 6.14) has also caused a steady stream of new dead to appear inside the cube. Gathered by the pixelated hellfire engine at area 6.41, they are regularly expelled onto the surface of face 1, whereupon the bronze scouts of face 2 drag the bodies around in a futile attempt to inter them, which ultimately distributes them across the surface of the cube. (The hellfire engine and the bronze scout appear in *Mordenkainen’s Tome of Foes*.)

THE PIXELATING CURSE

When any creature has been on the surface of the Changing Island for 10 minutes, and then each time it finishes a short or long rest while on or within the cube, it must attempt a DC 16 Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, the creature is infected with the

pixelating curse. Advantage on saving throws against magical effects applies, and chaotic creatures also have advantage on this save. Creatures that are immune to disease are immune to the curse.

The pixelating curse combines aspects of a traditional magical curse and a disease, and has both physical and mental components. If a creature is infected, the transmutation magic of the curse registers within them with a *detect magic* spell. The curse can be negated with a *cure disease*, *dispel magic*, *lesser restoration*, or *greater restoration* spell. Exposure to Styx water also ends the curse, including being fully immersed in the Styx sea or being doused by a bucket of Styx water. Once cured, though, a creature must leave the island within 10 minutes or make another Constitution save against becoming reinfected.

Once a creature has reached mental level 3 of the curse (see below), it no longer wants to be cured, and resists any attempts to cure it if it is conscious. To end the curse with one of the spells above, a spellcaster must succeed on an ability check using their spellcasting modifier, against a DC equal to 10 + the creature's Intelligence modifier. On a failed check, the creature remains pixelated and the spell is wasted.

The curse affects objects as well as living things. The effect on objects in a creature's possession is determined by the rate at which the creature is pixelating. Unattended objects (including things such as tents or gear left on the island while the characters explore) become pixelated within 1 hour. At your discretion, characters might need to attempt Wisdom (Perception) checks to recognize pixelated objects when they return to them. Magic items are not affected by the pixelating curse.

PHYSICAL EFFECTS

A creature under the effect of the pixelating curse slowly transforms into a 'blocky' version of itself, becoming more pixelated with each level of the curse's progression. Once infected, a creature gains one additional physical level of the curse at the end of each short rest. It gains two additional physical levels of the curse at the end of each long rest.

- **Physical Level 1:** No outwardly visible effects.
- **Physical Level 2:** Each pixel is smaller than a grain of rice. The effect is subtle enough that others might not notice unless the creature under the curse's effect is touched or closely inspected. Otherwise, an observer notices the effect only with a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check.
- **Physical Level 3:** Each pixel is the size of a small pearl. The curse is clearly visible to all observers.
- **Physical Level 4:** Each pixel is the size of a grape.
- **Physical Level 5:** Each pixel is the size of a strawberry.
- **Physical Level 6:** Each pixel is the size of a small apple. Once a creature has taken 6 physical levels of the curse, it gains the pixelated template (see below).

When a creature is first infected by the pixelating curse, roll a d6. On an odd result, it becomes infected from the inside out instead of outside in. The creature

NPCs AND THE CURSE

If the characters bring large numbers of mercenaries or other NPCs with them onto the island, you can choose to not roll saving throws for those characters. Rather, simply decide how the curse progresses through the ranks in whatever way seems most entertaining.

seems outwardly normal through the first 5 levels of the curse's physical progression, making it impossible to notice visually. However, if the creature is wounded by a piercing or slashing weapon, it bleeds red pixels of the appropriate size instead of blood.

MENTAL EFFECTS

Pixelated creatures are all linked into a group mind that regulates their behavior. Upon becoming infected, and each time it gains another physical level of the curse, a creature must attempt a DC 16 Charisma saving throw. Chaotic creatures have advantage on this save. On a failure, the creature gains 1 mental level of the curse. Because progression through the mental levels of the curse depend on progression through the physical levels, it's possible for an infected creature to be fully physically transformed but still retain its self-identity, or to appear only partially pixelated but be totally under the curse's mental control.

- **Mental Level 1:** The creature rolls once on the Mental Pixelation table. Additionally, it begins to suffer from hallucinations. To the infected creature, pixelated creatures and objects start to appear normal, while uninfected creatures and objects begin to appear as melting, chaotic, shapeless forms. If some of the characters are infected and some are not, players might have fun roleplaying whose perspective is real.
- **Mental Level 2:** The creature rolls for a second effect on the Mental Pixelation table, in addition to the original effect. Reroll if the original effect is rolled again.
- **Mental Level 3:** The creature's mind completely succumbs to the curse. Its alignment changes to lawful neutral and it suffers all the effects of the Mental Pixelation table simultaneously. In the case of a conflict, higher-numbered effects supersede lower-numbered ones. The creature also refuses to acknowledge that it is cursed, and does not willingly allow its own curse to be removed or help others remove the curse on themselves.

A creature at mental level 3 of the curse begins receiving weak telepathic transmissions from other pixelated creatures. While within 120 feet of another pixelated creature, the first creature can fully understand the transmissions, and is informed that the Archquadrone is their god, and that the skull lord and the pixelated mage are its divinely appointed representatives.

MENTAL PIXELATION

As noted on the Mental Pixelation table on the following page, the mental effects of the pixelating curse twist (or, rather, straighten) the cursed creature's mind toward absolute law. Though it retains its memories, the creature adopts lawful, conformist

behavior that supersedes its original personality. Players should be encouraged to roleplay cursed characters as stereotypical robots and “pod people,” as members of a fanatical cult, or as enthusiastic 1950s suburbanites.

Animals and other creatures of minimal intelligence that succumb to these effects might have them altered to better reflect instinct than intellect, as you determine.

TEMPLATE: PIXELATED

A pixelated creature resembles a crude outline of its original form, composed of individual blocks about

MENTAL PIXELATION

d10	Effect
1	The creature becomes obsessed with monetary value. At every opportunity, it must speculate on the cost in gold pieces of items that it, its companions, and its enemies are carrying.
2	The creature becomes obsessed with assessing weights. At every opportunity, it must speculate on the weight of items that it, its companions, and its enemies are carrying.
3	The creature becomes obsessed with measuring distances. At every opportunity, it must comment on the dimensions of objects, the range or reach of attacks, and so on.
4	The creature becomes obsessed with having a “normal” appearance. It sheds or stores away any unique garments and gear, trying to adopt the average look of most members of the party.
5	The creature becomes obsessed with its speech and mannerisms conforming to established norms. It loses any personal flourishes to its interactions with others, and might adopt the mannerisms of other characters in an attempt to blend in.
6	The creature becomes obsessed with logic and shuns emotional engagement. It focuses on the desire to work, the satisfaction of a job well done, and suspicion of others that look or think differently.
7	The creature develops a distaste of curved things, and avoids their use if possible (for example, stowing a bow or axe in order to attack with a sword).
8	The creature begins to hear happy voices promising a better way of life. (These are glimmers of the telepathy that all pixelated creatures share.)
9	The creature becomes obsessed with hierarchy and social authority. A character with the noble or soldier background might demand respect from allies and enemies. Other characters might speak respectfully of authority figures and become meek in their presence. (This mental effect culminates in the creature recognizing the skull lord as its master.)
10	The creature becomes a religious fanatic if it was already pious, or it becomes a militant atheist if not. When the creature meets the skull lord or sees the Archquadrone, it abandons its former faith (or lack thereof) to worship the Archquadrone as a god.

the size of a small apple. Pixelated creatures have their facial features (including eyes), fingers, toes, and teeth lost in the mass of blocks, although they retain their senses and their ability to eat, drink and speak. Pixelated creatures rarely talk, however, preferring to communicate with one another telepathically.

Pixelated natural attacks and weapons retain any ability to pierce and slash, even though they appear to be blunt and cubical.

Intelligent pixelated creatures seek out the skull lord and the Archquadrone, seeking to serve it as soldiers and stewards in an instinctive hierarchy. Animals and other creatures of minimal intelligence continue to behave normally, following their own instincts. But they defend any pixelated creature they see being attacked by an unpixelated one.

A pixelated creature has the following traits.

- Its alignment is lawful neutral.
- It has telepathy out to a range of 120 feet, but can use it to communicate only with other pixelated creatures.
- It is immune to the frightened condition.
- It has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made to hide while in a pixelated area.

As with all creatures under the effect of the pixelating curse, being immersed in the Styx sea instantly changes a pixelated creature back to normal. A small splash of the black water causes a pixelated creature distress but has no other effect. Being doused by a full bucket of Styx water will cause one Medium or smaller creature to revert. Treat throwing a bucket of water as a weapon attack (range 5/15), with advantage if the bucket is wielded two-handed.

A Large or larger pixelated creature struck with a bucket of Styx water can attempt a DC 15 Intelligence saving throw to resist changing back. Such creatures require multiple buckets of Styx water to change back, as you determine.

THE STYX SEA

As the characters draw closer, the first sign they see of their destination is a low bank of fog obscuring a small, flat island in the distance.

They then see the change in the water. The relatively clear, blue-green water of the sea meets a current of silty black liquid, which doesn’t mix with the seawater. The black water surrounds the island to a distance of a quarter mile on all sides. It is fresh water, although it has a strange smell reminiscent of alchemy and sweet perfume. Colder than the surrounding sea, it is also noticeably chilly to the touch.

A successful DC 15 Intelligence (Nature) check indicates that the water is more like river water than seawater. A successful DC 20 Intelligence (Religion) check recognizes the water’s scent as similar to cassia (a spice that smells like cinnamon), natron (mineral salts), and bitumen (tar)—three ingredients that are used together in some cultures to mummify the dead. If the Intelligence (Religion) check result is 25 or higher, the character is reminded of old legends of the River Styx—the cold, dark river of the Lower Planes in which the memories of the dead are washed away.